@shedarestogo

SLEIGH SOLO

DONE FOR YOU CHRISTMAS MARKET WEEKEND

Bethlehem Pennsylvania

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Hey!

I'm Shaneice, the creator of @shedarestogo.

This is your blueprint for an amazing weekend in Christmas City USA!

As a solo mom who's spent a full weekend with an 8-year-old exploring the Bethlehem, Pennsylvania Christmas Market and experiences, I'm giving you the best parts of our adventures.

Inside this time saving guide, I'm giving you all the lessons, easy-to-follow itineraries, and answers to all your questions so you can have an epic weekend without the stress of trying to figure out every detail.

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How to Use This Guide

You can use this guide in two ways:

- Read through the details and pick which itinerary is best for you. Only two decisions: Itinerary A or Itinerary B.
- Use the table of contents to plan your own custom itinerary based on what you're interested in.

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Know Before You Go

KEY DETAILS

The market: Christkindlmarkt, PNC Plaza at SteelStacks, Bethlehem, PA

Website: https://www.artsquest.org/christkindlmarkt/

Hours: Thu and Sun 10-6, Fri and Sat 10-8

Tickets: Online purchase $14 Thu/Fri, $16.50 Sat/Sun, kids 5 and under free, FREE Fridays 5-8 PM

Drive: about 3.5 hours from Northern Virginia

Book everything in advance.

The Market

Christkindlmarkt, PNC Plaza at SteelStacks, Bethlehem, PA

2026 WEEKENDS: NOV 13-15, NOV 20-22, NOV 27-29, DEC 3-6, DEC 10-13, DEC 17-20

OVER 170 ARTISAN VENDORS + A GERMAN-STYLE FOOD HALL

What Is a Christmas Market?

A Christmas market is an open-air German-style holiday village with rows of vendors, good food, lights everywhere, mulled wine, gifts you cannot find at the mall. Bethlehem's is one of the best in the country and Travel + Leisure put it on its coolest Christmas markets in the US list!

But is it worth a trip...?

YES!

This is the trip that made my daughter and me feel like we were inside a holiday movie. The nostalgia, the decor, the ambience. And this guide exists so the worth it part does not cost you ten hours of planning to find out.

Bethlehem's nickname is Christmas City, USA. It earns it.

When is the Best Time to Go to Avoid Crowds?

Fridays: Free entry to Christkindlmarkt from 5-8 PM.

On weekends: Arrive at opening, or in the last two hours before close.

The weekends before Thanksgiving are best for beating crowds.

For the fullest energy, the middle December weekends are the big ones.

Worst time to go to Christkindlmarkt - Midday on Saturdays between 1 and 4PM

Where Do I Park and Is it Free?

See Map on Page 16!

Park at the market in the SURFACE LOT for FREE. The parking garage has a fee.

The garage honestly looks a little sketchy but it is safe.

Wear VERY comfortable shoes because it is a LOT of walking. The market is MASSIVE.

Arrive early, the free lots are first come.

Downtown is about 1.7 miles from the market, and the free Christmas City Trolley runs between SteelStacks and the historic district, so you never have to repark.

We didn’t use the trolley because I like being able to come and go as I please, which is why staying a little outside downtown works (more on that later.)

Parking Hacks

The lots right next to the market are free, but first come, first served. Arrive at opening or in the last two hours, not midday.

Explore the Market Like a Pro

- Go straight for the German-style food in the food hall, skip the food trucks near the entrance.
- Start toward the END of the market and work your way back toward the front.
- Shop vendors first at opening, eat after, then shop more to walk it off. The lights last if you are staying late.
- Bring a big bag so you can put your small bags inside of it. There is a LOT to buy.
- **Santa and kids' activities can be found at Saint Nicholas Haus.**
- **Things to Note:** This location no longer does ice skating. Skip the overpriced food trucks, there's nowhere to sit and eat anyways. The mulled wine is sold by the bottle and it is amazing. Tastings are available.
- Cashless, so no ATM panic, and bring the spending money anyway for the little stuff (page 28).

Where Do We Stay?

MY PICK: COURTYARD
MARRIOTT BETHLEHEM/LEHIGH
VALLEY

15 MINS FROM DOWNTOWN

I picked this on purpose. Not downtown, so I am not paying downtown prices, and that money goes to the fun parts of the weekend instead.

Which Hotel is Best for You?

Two Options to Find the best hotel:

Option 1: Big budget = Closer Location
Stay downtown. You spend more money and you will have to pay for hotel parking, but downtown is very walkable, and you can take the trolley to the Christmas Market. You can also drive there.

Option 2: Medium Budget + Drive in
Stay 10-15 minutes away. Spend less money on the stay and get free parking, but you have to pay for parking only when you're downtown. **This is what I did.**

Closest to the market: stay on the South Side, under a mile from the Christmas Market gates.
The next page gives you 6 hotels if you like options.

The Hotels, Compared

Courtyard by Marriott Bethlehem Lehigh Valley,, about $144-$199 a night, 15 minutes from downtown, my pick

Wind Creek Bethlehem,, about $150-$240 a night, 0.6 miles from the market, the closest bed, it is a casino resort.

Comfort Suites (South Side),, about $110-$160, under a mile, free hot breakfast and free parking.

Historic Hotel Bethlehem,, about $240-$380, downtown Main Street, the splurge.

Hyatt Place Bethlehem,, about $140-$210, downtown.

Hampton Inn & Suites,, about $120-$175, 10 minutes out, free parking and a pool.

Prices as of 1 November. Prices are typical market weekend ranges and subject to change. Tap your link for your exact weekend.

Where to Stay, Eat, and Explore (map on next page)

1 ChristkindImarkt at SteelStacks, 645 E First St

2 Wind Creek Bethlehem, 77 Wind Creek Blvd

3 Comfort Suites, 120 W 3rd St

4 Historic Hotel Bethlehem + Tap Room + 1741 on the Terrace, 437 Main St

5 Hyatt Place, 45 W North St

6 Hampton Inn & Suites, 200 Gateway Dr (10 minutes north)

7 Apollo Grill, 85 W Broad St

8 Mama Nina's, 546 Main St

9 Fegley's Brew Works, 569 Main St

10 Bitty & Beau’s Coffee, 74 Broad St

11 Santa at the Moravian Blacksmith Shop, historic district

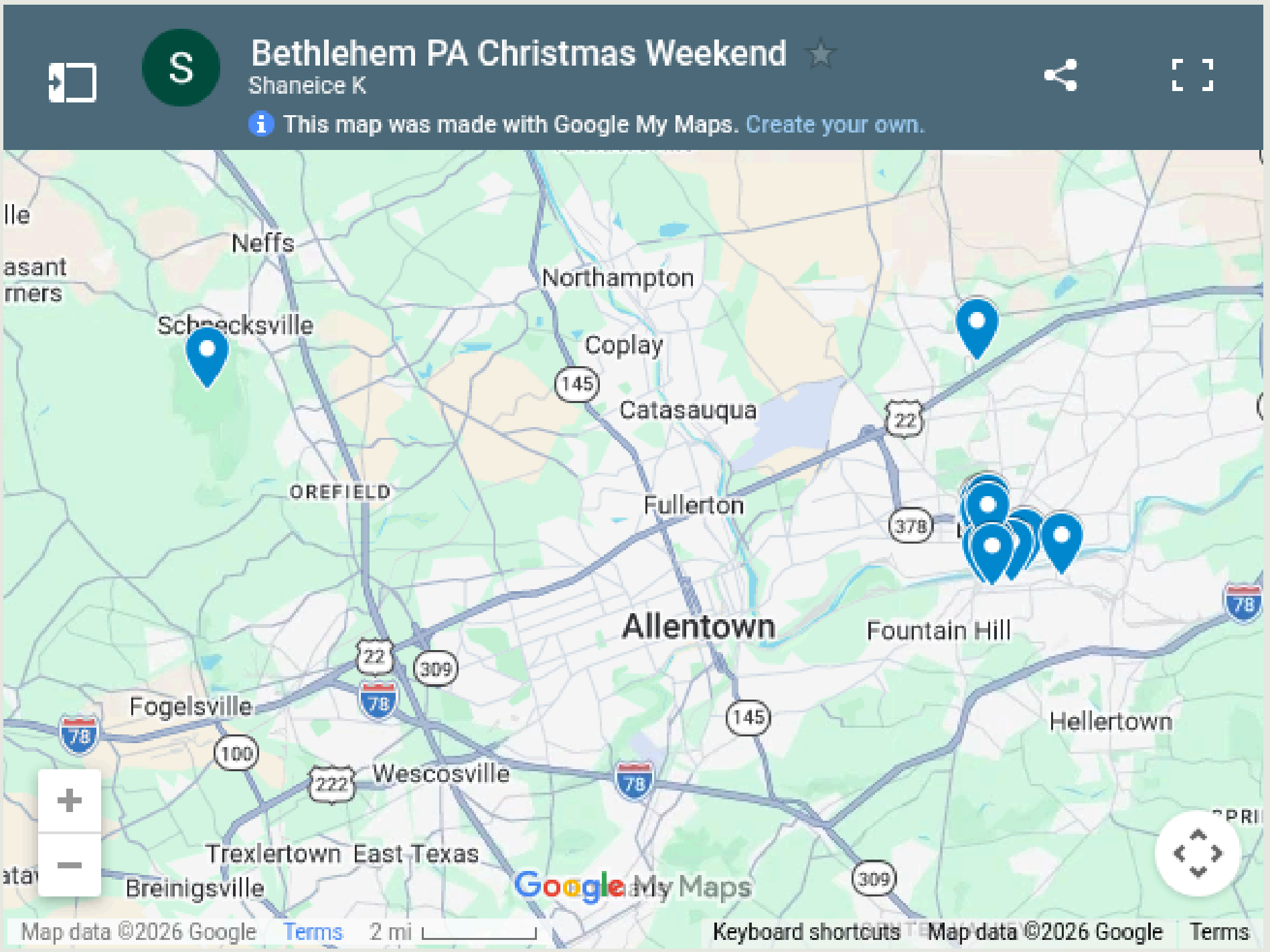
12 Sun Inn courtyard mini Christmas market, historic district

13 Lehigh Valley Zoo (about 40 minutes away, worth it, page 26)

Pins 4, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12 cluster within a few blocks of Main Street, park once and walk it all.

Your Interactive Map with Pinned Locations

Tap the Map to get my pins with exact locations sorted by experiences, food and beverages, and lodging.



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flying
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TAP

Where Do We Eat, and What Do I Book First?

My FAVORITES HANDS DOWN!

Bitty & Beau's Coffee (first come first served) - Cozy Breakfast

Apollo Grill (Reservations Required - Nice Dinner

The Tap Room (Reservations Required) - Fancy Lunch & Dinner

https://bethlehembarrelanddrafthouse.com/ - Easy Lunch

BOOKING ORDER:

Book the hotel first.

Then book food (because you usually know when you get the hungriest)

Then book activities.

The Restaurants, Compared

Apollo Grill, my dinner pick, cozy and laid back, $20-$60 per person, reservations a must, closed Sun/Mon.

The Tap Room at Hotel Bethlehem, breakfast that feels like a winter wonderland, also great for dinner, $30 and under, book on OpenTable.

1741 on the Terrace, the fancy night, $40-$70, very pricey and worth it once.

Bethlehem Barrel & Drafthouse, American style pub, food is AW ESOME, $20-30, lots of seating.

Mama Nina's, family Italian, huge portions, BYOB keeps the bill kind, $15-$30.

Fegley's Brew Works, the easy kid-friendly dinner, $15-$25.

McCarthy's Red Stag Pub, cozy Irish comfort food, $15-$30.

Johnny's Bagels, the no reservation lunch, $8-$15.

Bitty & Beau's Coffee, the morning start, amazing coffee, $5-$12.

DONE FOR YOU ITINERARIES

OPTION A: CHRISTMAS MARKET IN THE MORNING

OPTION B: CHRISTMAS MARKET AT NIGHT

OPTION A: Day Market

For early risers and younger kids.

FRIDAY

- Arrive by noon,
- Johnny's Bagels lunch,
- Santa by 2 at Moravian Blacksmith Shop
- Hotel Bethlehem lobby photos,
- Sun Inn Mini Christmas Village
- Apollo Grill dinner (reserved), early night.
- Drive to Lehigh Valley Zoo and spend the night walking through the most epic Christmas light displays on the East Coast.

SATURDAY

- Bitty & Beau's Coffee or hotel breakfast (no reservations required)
- Christmas market at 10 AM opening to get surface lot parking
- Vendor shopping until 2PM,
- German food hall for late lunch.
- Rest/reset at hotel
- Evening Horse & Carriage Ride at Bethlehem Carriage Company
- Tap Room for dinner or choose one from the restaurants list
- Stroll through downtown Bethlehem

SUNDAY:

- Peoples Kitchen on Linden (first come first serve, opens at 7AM(
- free trolley for any last look, on the road early afternoon, home before dark.

OPTION B: Night Market

For the lights. The market is best at night, that is a firsthand verdict, not a guess.

FRIDAY

- Arrive by noon & grab Johnny's Bagels
- Explore Moravian district in afternoon light & see Santa at BlackSmith Shop (Arrive by 3PM)
- Quick bite at Fegley’s or Pre-pack snacks to hold you over until you get to Christkindlmarkt
- Arrive at Christkindlmarkt by 4:30PM to get ahead of traffic and get a parking spot for free admission Friday from 5PM - 8PM

SATURDAY:

- Bitty & Beau's on Main Street for breakfast, first come, first served. Arrive by 9AM.
- Explore downtown and grab lunch - explore downtown Main Street shops
- Early morning Horse & Carriage ride at Bethlehem Carriage Company
- Red Stag or Mama Nina's for lunch, then rest at the hotel in the afternoon
- Light Dinner and then head to Lehigh Valley Zoo Lights from 5PM - 9PM

SUNDAY: Tap Room brunch (make reservations now), trolley, last Main Street pass, home before dark

WHERE IS SANTA AND WHAT ELSE IS DOWNTOWN??

Santa at the Moravian Blacksmith Shop:
FREE, and he closes around 4:30 PM. Be in line by 2 PM to see him.

Santa at the St. Nicholas Haus:
Free to see, pictures at a cost.
Pro Tip: Use your cell phone if they let you.

Take pictures in the Historic Hotel Bethlehem
Extremely beautiful, free, it can get crowded, go before dark.

Experience Mass at the beautiful Holy Infancy Roman Catholic Church

Santa Sleigh Rides through Downtown
Reserve your spot on Santa's sleigh with Bethlehem Carriage Company - Book far in advance. It sells out FAST.

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Free Outdoor Nativity Scene
Payrow Plaza, The life-size outdoor nativity stands next to the city's Christmas tree on the plaza in front of City Hall, right by the Bethlehem Area Public Library

EXTRA DETAILS YOU CANNOT SKIP

Zoo Lights in Lehigh Valley

Lehigh Valley Zoo, Winter Light Spectacular. Themed light worlds, Frozen, candy cane world, movies on the barn. My favorite stop of the whole trip. Book well in advance, but check their refund policy in the event of bad weather.

Disclaimer: It is about a 40 minute drive out through the countryside, and at night that drive feels long. It is still worth it, and knowing it is coming is the whole difference.

Pro Tip: Wear LAYERS. Lots of layers. Pennsylvania cold is a different cold.

What to Pack & Tips That Make your Day Easier

It gets VERY COLD in the valley.

Wear layers for both of you, base, warm middle, coat. The zoo and the market at night are standing outside cold.

Hats, gloves, warm socks, and ear muffs. Toe warmers and hand warmers.

Comfortable walking shoes, downtown is cobblestone.

A small bag for market finds so you are not juggling.

Car kit basics for a winter drive, and do not let the gas drop below a quarter tank on the zoo drive.

How Much Will Everything Cost?

The BIGGEST costs will be before you show up. You must book in advance, otherwise you will probably be paying double or scrambling if things are sold out.

As a solo mom with one child, I spent about $780. ($250 for hotel, $80 for parking and gas, $150 for food, $300 for activities and shopping)

Market tickets: $14-$16.50, kids 5 and under free, and Friday 5-8 PM is free.

Bring about $300 in spending money for market finds and cocoa and the little stuff, separate from tickets and dinner money.

Hotels: pick your lane on page 13, $110 to $380 a night is the whole honest range.

A Christmas market weekend done wrong can easily cost $1,200 and up for two people. Done in this order, it does not.

If Things Sell Out: Your Plan B

If the market is packed
Downtown there is a second market, the free Christmas City Village, wooden huts along Main Street and in the Sun Inn Courtyard, Fridays through Sundays, 11 AM to 7 PM.

If the Lehigh Valley Zoo Lights are sold out
Drive about 20 minutes to Lights in the Parkway in Allentown instead. It is a drive-through light show, $16 per car for the whole family, November 27 to January 6, 5:30 to 10 PM.

If every restaurant is booked

- Grab Johnny's Bagels and Deli downtown
- Dine nearby in Freemansburg PA (10 minute drive)
- Go further out to Easton PA for authentic eats (20 minutes away)
- Eat in at the German food in the market food hall.

My Solo Mom Rules for This Weekend

I did not stay downtown on purpose to save money, but it can be worth it if you want to do as little driving as possible.
Do not stay in a low-rated hotel to save money. Sometimes they can be in sketchy areas.

Driving after dark is pretty safe, but there is an area toward the Lehigh Valley Zoo Lights that loses cell service. It can feel sketchy, but it only lasts about 10 minutes.

I never tell anyone that I'm solo with my daughter, I always say my husband is trailing behind.

I always share my location and I check-in with a friend before I leave and when I get back.

Your Helpful Links

- Christkindlmarkt tickets and info: ArtsQuest, Christkindlmarkt
- Lehigh Valley Zoo, Winter Light Spectacular: lvzoo.org
- Santa and Holidays at the Moravian Blacksmith Shop: Historic Bethlehem, Blacksmith Shop
- Moravian Putz nativity: Central Moravian Church, Christmas Putz
- Historic Bethlehem tours and Christmas City Stroll: historicbethlehem.org
- Christmas City Village and downtown events: Discover Lehigh Valley, Bethlehem at the Holidays
- Lights in the Parkway tickets: allentownpa.gov/LITP, event page: Discover Lehigh Valley, Lights in the Parkway
- Santa Sleigh Rides with Bethlehem Carriage Company - It sells out quickly!

Thanks for your purchase!

I hope this guide gave you everything you're looking for! If you have more questions, email hello@shedarestogo.com

-Shaneice

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